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David Torkanowsky

David Torkanowsky has an active career in music as a pianist, arranger and producer. He is a native of New Orleans and his piano style reflects the vitality of that city's important musical culture.

David was interviewed in New Hartford, NY on September 26, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have David Torkanowsky here for a college concert, Fallcoming Jazz we call it, at Hamilton, 26 years we've been doing this concert in the fall. And the room you'll be playing in has graced such people as Dick Hyman and Bucky Pizzarelli, Clark Terry, and Sweets, who you were mentioning before.

DT: So you couldn't get anybody good.

MR: I was watching you about two hours ago, and I think we got somebody good.

DT: All right, thanks.

MR: And I want to start with an odd question. It's not a question it's like can we talk about eighth notes?

DT: Sure.

MR: When I was listening to you play, you did "Body and Soul" but you did a tune before that and I didn't catch the name of it, it might have just been a —

DT: It could have been an extemporaneous — I can't think of what to play let me play something until I think of something.

MR: Exactly. But you went through, the feel of the music changed as you progressed. And I think it has a lot to do with the series of eighth notes, whether they're straight, whether they're really swingy.

DT: Well listen you know jazz was the popular music of a certain time. And then at some point rock & roll became the popular music. Now what was the transition? Well the eighth note was carrying the water. So in jazz music the eighth note we consider to be the first and last of a triplet [scats]. You know it's interesting, when I teach young drummers how to swing on a cymbal I teach them, "Draw a quarter note on the left hand — draw a quarter note here, a dotted eighth here, and a sixteenth here. And put your stick right on that. Sorry. Put the quarter note here, dotted eighth here, sixteenth here. [Scats] and keep that rhythm. Keep that pattern. Now as you go faster, that becomes more eighth notes and the pattern becomes small [scats]. As you go slower the pattern becomes wider and this sixteenth note moves closer to the quarter note. [Scats]. Now that's the way old cats used to play a ballad. Young cats rarely cross the triplet [scats]. Dig? But you know the pattern is still the same. And so what happens? Two things happen. First of all, a little more arm.

It's swinging. Secondly, you have to [scats] on the backbeat you have to lift the stick and travel so that puts it — that makes the cymbal pattern swing. So that illustrates the movable eighth note. Now I think what you're asking me is, in swing [scats] you know the funky players, Phil Woods for example, he would straighten out eighth notes because that made him sound funky. Horace Silver, the two fathers of funk to me are Horace Silver and Professor Longhair. Professor Longhair comes more out of a Caribbean rumba tradition. But and Horace Silver [scats] he was one of the first cats to straighten out the eighth notes. Now what you heard me play on that WWOZ post is kind of straight eighth notes with a little junk to it. Now if you ever heard of J.C. Heard play a bossa nova it was [scats] and it would kind of stretch the swing eighth notes, but somewhere between swing and straight, and you know where that is and you know it's up to personal discretion, but it's stretched eighth notes. Dr. John did the same thing [scats], and that's kind of the way Smoky Johnson in New Orleans started playing funk. These cats all came out of a jazz tradition. Kind of shuffle became straight eighth notes. So it's in that area that I like to explore because it puts a tear into the music. Now I've done straight recording sessions where they want me to play very precise. And I think I'm playing straight eighth notes and the producer says, "Hey man, it's cool, but can you not swing it so much?" I didn't realize I was. So I hope that answers your question.

MR: That's more than answered my question. I'm really fascinated by that because there's a couple of Chuck Berry records for instance —

DT: Oh please, please. We can't talk about Chuck Berry?

MR: We can't?

DT: He's the only guy that ever fired me. You want to hear that story?

MR: I do.

DT: Okay. Quint Davis, George Wein's protégé, booked me and a great bass player named George French and a drummer who played with Alvin Batiste out of Baton Rouge named Herman Jackson as his rhythm section for an entire European tour. Unbeknownst to me Chuck wanted the great — was it James Johnson? The great Sun Records.

MR: Jimmy —

DT: John Johnson.

MR: Johnny Johnson.

DT: Johnny Johnson, thank you. The great Sun records session player. He wanted him to come along as kind of an M.D. And George Wein, who just had to wire $400,000 into Chuck Berry's account ahead of the tour, because that was part of the deal, said absolutely not. If you want Johnny Johnson to come you've got to pay for him. I didn't know any of this at the time. So we had one gig at Penn's Landing in Philadelphia as a warm-up for this entire European tour and Chuck Berry was great. So we're here, the

place is packed. Outdoor arena right on the river, beautiful, like an amphitheater. The place is packed. Nobody has seen Chuck Berry.

MR: No rehearsal.

DT: Oh no, no, no, no. No. But we got together and played through some of his tunes in New Orleans. So it was late, and the crowd was getting restless. What I didn't know at the time was this was a standard Chuck Berry thing — he sits in his Cadillac with the engine running, sort of near the stage, waiting for somebody to bring him a briefcase of cash before he hits the stage. And this obviously wasn't included in the George Wein European tour that he got paid in advance for. So he got that — all of a sudden I see what looks like a rugby scrum of security coming through the stage. And in the middle of that scrum is Chuck Berry. All of a sudden he explodes on the stage [scats] and it's groovin'. And he is so happy 'cause we know his music and we're kind of putting that New Orleans stank on it. And you know he says, "Oh man, they usually send kids to play with me. This is great." He was really happy. And after a solo, "Y'all ever hear a white boy play blues like that?" You know, really — this is great, this is working out great. So after a particular solo that he kind of built me up for to the crowd, the crowd — you know I finished it you know with a flourish or whatever. And you know I'm trying to do my best Jerry Lee type shit. And the crowd goes, "Haaaaaa" you know the crowd went crazy. Chuck Berry looked at the crowd, looked at me, put his hands on his hips, let his guitar fall to the ground [clang] it was feeding back. And he walked off stage you know. And we were shuffling, that's part of the tune, we didn't know. So I didn't know what to do, I just pulled a microphone, "Ladies and gentlemen, Chuck Berry!" And made it seem like it was the end of the show. Well at two in the morning Quint Davis calls me and he goes, "Bro, man, I have to replace you on the tour. Chuck Berry wants to use Johnny Johnson you know, because he thought you know, you stole his thunder, whatever." I forgot how they put it. And of course I was crushed. I still made George pay me for the tour but I was crushed because oh my God, I just got fired by Chuck Berry. I didn't realize there was this other agenda that he's getting out of having to pay Johnny Johnson. But still, I don't like to talk about Chuck Berry even though he was great.

MR: Well thank you for that story. It's one of those things, you got fired for playing too good you know?

DT: That's my story. I don't think I did anything else wrong.

MR: Well I guess I was going to say that some of those early records of him, I hear him playing [scats] and the band is like a little mystified, right?

DT: The band is playing a straight shuffle and he's like straight ahead. I love that. Because you're listening to how rock & roll was born. And it's just that gangster kind of — oh gangster shuffle.

MR: Okay. Can you define skank?

DT: Sure. It's related to the straight eighth notes that we're talking about. It's behind the beat. It's attitude. It's slop — intentional sloppiness without being pretentious about it.

MR: Yeah but you said —

DT: You know who had skank?

MR: Who?

DT: Johnny "Guitar" Watson.

MR: Okay.

DT: And I challenge you to tell me what his original instrument was. He was a pianist. And if — they're hard to find, but if you find that Johnny "Guitar" Watson, before it was Guitar Watson, Little Johnny Watson, whatever, piano trio recordings, he's singing "Witchcraft," "Willow Weep for Me," "I Cried for You," a beautiful tune called "When Did You Leave Heaven." I mean unbelievable. And it's like these recordings should be used as classroom materials to teach young drummers and bass players how to play behind a singer, just beautiful and framing the lyrics, just beautiful. And he didn't play guitar — he went to a Gatemouth Brown concert, Gatemouth Brown from Lake Charles, Louisiana, and he saw him play guitar and he goes, "Oh my God, I want to play guitar." And he taught himself how to play guitar, and then when you realize on these Johnny "Guitar" Watson tracks you know, he's playing all the keyboards. He was an incredible musician. Fantastic. But listen, see if you can cop those original Johnny "Guitar" Watson piano trio recordings. They are absolutely astounding. Because it's his voice. [sings] I cried for you — it's so killer, so killer.

MR: Well you just said playing a little sloppy without being pretentious. And I can see how that would be difficult for a musician who might say, "I want to move to New Orleans and get in the music scene."

DT: A lot of people do that, because it's the last place left that has ancestral resonance in the music that's being played today.

MR: Okay.

DT: You know I mean you play at Preservation Hall and the bass player is putting his peg in the hole that's been worn in the wood that's been there since the seventeen hundreds that other bass players have put untold hours of energy and so it's hard not to feel what came before. And that's leaving us in New Orleans, but it's still there as opposed to most everywhere else.

MR: But feeling — how do I say this? Consciously trying to play behind the beat is hard. It has to come natural, right? And how do you make it natural?

DT: You play with people that do it naturally, and you understand, oh man, I'm really comfortable here. And then it becomes part of your vocabulary.

MR: Okay. You don't take it kindly when people or writers or something say yeah New Orleans is back to where it was.

DT: Oh well that's interesting you should say that because somebody asked me to — there's a French bread company in New Orleans called Leidenheimer's. French bread is the bread that po' boys are made out of. And so it's a real old family art. And he said, "Hey a friend of mine, journalist, wants to write a story about how New Orleans came back." And I wrote this scathing blistering letter about are you kidding me? You know Katrina was a cultural cataclysm that exploded decades of aural, like A-U-R-A-L and oral, O-R-A-L traditions. It broke up — the thing that makes New Orleans cool is musical families. You know grandfathers teaching grandsons how to play banjo or guitar, piano, even kids today putting their fingers where the player piano's keys are depressed and they learn that way. Family members teaching descendents how to play in musical families, the Marsalis family, the Neville family, that's at least current. The Lastie family which begat Herlin Riley and the Brunious family. All these families have currently working exponents that are doing the legacy of their family. And it's interesting, they play based on what neighborhood they grew up in, you know, Seventh Ward Creoles play time a little differently. There's Sixth Ward second line, which has a little different flavor than Ninth Ward second line. Shannon Powell, a great New Orleans drummer, last of his kind, Louis Bellson level, won *Down Beat* awards best drummer of the year when he was playing with Harry Connick, Jr. He's from the Sixth Ward. He's the proponent of Sixth Ward second line and they have their own little nuances as opposed to Ninth Ward second line. So the point is the place is very special. And unfortunately my ADD kicked in and I lost my thread.

MR: You were talking about people assuming or saying that it's back to where it was.

DT: Oh, I'm sorry, you're right. So I wrote this scathing response saying that you know I mean listen, after Katrina happened the then-speaker of the house Denny Hastert actually said, "New Orleans is going to be too expensive to rebuild. If people want to hear jazz they can go to Walt Disney World." Yeah he said that. The letter I wrote him I'm surprised I didn't get a knock on the door from the Secret Service 'cause it was pretty caustic. But the point is no, no, no. I mean here's the thing. New Orleans — jazz was born of the confluence of the African diaspora and the European — New Orleans was the opera capital of the world, of the hemisphere in the 1700s. There was opera going on. You know there was African rhythms going on. Those two combined, people risked going to jail because integration was against the law and musicians were routinely, when they were caught jamming together, rounded up by the police and sent to jail. The point is the energy of New Orleans is what created its art. Katrina — I guess here's the thing — I was asking a post-conviction capital defense attorney — last American heroes left —

why music flourished in New Orleans, why the creativity? She said, that's easy, leisure time. In New Orleans, I mean it's not called "The Big Easy" for nothing. And you know you could always go by so-and-so mama's house who got some gumbo on the stove and you could make zero dollars in New Orleans and eat just fine. So people hung out, they hung out with each other and they shedded and they created, you know, music, like Ellis Marsalis, the quintet, the early quintet. They — James Black. They influenced Coltrane and his quartet when they came and hung in New Orleans. They influenced — there was a great tenor player named Nat Perrilliat who was playing sheets of sound while Coltrane was still playing two fives. And you know New Orleans has an incredible power, like even to this day. And I'm sorry this is kind of rambling all over the map answer, but even to this day there's a soul food restaurant on Esplanade called Lil Dizzy's Café, owned by the Baquet family. One of their sons is Dean Baquet, the editor of the *New York Times*. We have influence — the culture informs on a global level. And what happened during Katrina was this indigenous, rich heritage of multiple generations of French, Spanish, African-American, Italian, Irish, all of these people had their neighborhoods and they interacted with each other. And most of the white people were raised by black people. There was a separation of the races but there was a communing of the races you know, informally, both artistically and socially. After Katrina all of that leisure time that I spoke of earlier, that went away, because predatory investors came in and bought up all the housing stock, fixed up all the houses. The rents became Manhattan-level rents, and the salaries did not follow. So the indigenous people, the people who sat on the front stoop checking out the latest Sonny Stitt record wondering how that fit in and trying to cop the notes, those people suddenly had to work two or three jobs just to afford the place they lived in all their lives. And it was a cultural genocide. So I didn't have any patience for the writer that said, "Oh I'm writing a piece about how it's all back now." No it's not. Now I understand all culture erodes. I understand that. Culture changes. You know when I came out as a kid it was like man, I was playing with Danny Barker on Bourbon Street for six hours then I'd go play a bebop gig with James Black and Earl Turpentine after. And then at six in the morning we'd go to somebody's house and shed 'til noon. It was like amazing. And I said wow, this is really — and the old cats were saying this ain't nothing like it used to be. Man we used to be this and this and this. Now you know kids go on Frenchman Street and play for the door, and mostly out of town musicians that are playing 20s and 30s swing music that tourists think is New Orleans traditional music. They don't know the difference. Incidentally, a side note, the difference, we never call it Dixieland because of the word Dixie, and because Dixieland music didn't start in New Orleans. The first jazz record contract was offered to Freddie Keppard, a jazz trumpet player that was a contemporary of Buddy Bolden's, by Verve Records. But in what has

proved to be a long history of New Orleans musicians either over or under-valuing themselves he asked for way too much money. So the first jazz record contract went to five white guys from Kansas City called the Original Dixieland Jazz Band and that was the moniker for the music. We call it traditional New Orleans music. The thing about Dixieland — it sounds like circus music [scats]. For us there's when to play two [scats] and that has to do with the second line in the streets, when to play two and when to play four on the bass, and the drummer would walk in four. And those sections, like in trios, when I say trios I'm talking about "Original Dixieland One-Step" [scats] you know they're like John Philip Sousa type marches and they have different key areas but [scats] they're very specific parts. There's time — how many times do you repeat each section? When do you play two? When do you play four? These are all part of traditional New Orleans music that Dixieland players rarely if ever acknowledge. So that's the basic difference.

MR: I'm so glad you made a distinction and you included A-U-R-A-L and O-R-A-L. Because a lot of times you read jazz was an oral music — O-R-A-L. And I thought not really — I mean it's more about the ears. The things you're describing people just have to like soak it up by hearing it and then learning how to do it.

DT: It's like for instance Zigaboo, one of the greatest drummers to come from New Orleans. He was the drummer for the Meters. He spent almost every night of his life by a back screen door listening to Idris Muhammad play bebop. And if you hear him play, once I heard him — I heard Zigaboo play a gig with Sam Rivers. Sam Rivers was a kind of an avant garde tenor saxophonist. He put the horn in his mouth and 55 minutes later the set was over. You know, just incredible, just stream of consciousness. Zigaboo was like just playing stuff I'd never heard him play. As a matter of fact I had a group with Zigaboo, George Porter on bass, Nicholas Payton and myself. We called it Fleur Debris. And I mean Zigaboo sounded like Elvin. I mean just amazing. So part of the New Orleans tradition is that we grew up having to play many different styles. And so there was no, like it was all just New Orleans music. Like if I were to ask you what is New Orleans music what would you say?

MR: I honestly couldn't answer.

DT: I know. Is it Al Hirt? Is it the Neville Brothers? Is it Mannie Fresh? Is it Pete Fountain? What is it? It's like it's not a style it's an attitude of playing music under water. Because in New Orleans we're under water. Danny Barker used to say that. That's why trumpet players from there, that's why Nicholas Payton, Al Hirt, that's why these trumpet players have such a big sound. It's like you know you go to a baseball game and a batter puts weights on his bats and swings it? They have to push against this weight to get a sound. You know this weight of the humidity in the air. The drummers have to work a little extra

to get the sound waves to push the water out of the way so we can hear it. I know that sounds a little metaphysical. But the point is creating and performing music below sea level is a different physical process than gasping for air in Denver or playing bebop in New York. So that's part of why people from New Orleans sound different. I mean what sets New Orleans pianists apart? I mean Allen Toussaint sounded very French, very ornate, very French. Louis Moreau Gottschalk was in fact French. James Booker did a lot of Chopin affectations and — affectations is the wrong word because that makes it sound less than it was. He assimilated a lot of Chopin's appoggiaturas and flourishing in what he played. What is the one aspect that all New Orleans pianists, indigenous New Orleans pianists, share? Humidity. They're playing sounds humid. It sounds like you could, like Allen's song "Southern Nights." You could sit on a porch and just listen to the locusts and the piano would be a score for that. And so it's a real magical place that I'm sorry to say is in cultural decline in the midst of homogony and — what's the word when a place gets bouged up?

MR: Oh I know what you're talking about.

DT: Yeah. That word.

MR: It's like Brooklyn.

DT: Well yeah. Yeah, yeah.

MR: Gen —

DT: Gentrification. Exactly, thank you. And so that's what's happening. That's what's happening. You know it's sad to see but thankfully there's institutions like WWOZ and the New Orleans Jazz & Heritage Festival that are kind of working to memorialize that and still support the guys from the old school that are still trying to do it.

MR: Yeah. When you were talking about the force of the trumpet players and the drummers.

DT: And trombone players.

MR: It made me think of Sidney Bechet, who is like with that soprano sax like a laser.

DT: And his vibrato. You notice how his vibrato is church-like? Like, oh come on the Gospel singer, the famous Gospel singer.

MR: Mahalia Jackson?

DT: Yes. Has that power. And it's the same thing, the church informed the music quite a bit. You know Herlin Riley to this day, his father was a minister, sorry, his grandfather was a minister and so was his grandmother. He won't play "When the Saints Go Marching In" if it's not in church. You know it's like that's sacred music and this is a secular venue, we're not going to do that. So I've seen him at festivals and the band leader calls "Saints" and he would just lay out. You know?

MR: Do a Chuck Berry on him.

DT: Oh yeah. I thought I told you not to mention that.

MR: I'm sorry. Last time.

DT: Sure.

MR: So from a piano playing standpoint I'm wondering if there's five really accomplished piano players, lots of technique, why does one of them get more calls than the other?

DT: Oh, you mean calls for work?

MR: Yes.

DT: Oh well that could be if he's a snappy dresser. But actually you know it boils down to — I was having this conversation the other day and this is a backwards way to answer your question, as most of my answers have been. Jazz music, playing on the bandstand is supposed to be a mature conversation among equals. And it's like oh you hear somebody say something, "Oh really," and you comment. And it's really high-minded in that sense. I can't really play — I used to play second keyboards for a time behind George Duke. And he used to tell me, he said, "Just as soon as you can stop being a fan." Because I was playing like — I was trying to play like — that's my shit, you play your shit. And I'm on the bandstand with Nicholas Payton and it's so transformative, it's like the closest I'm ever going to get to play with Miles. He's deeper by a factor of ten than anyone else playing music right now. And you know he'll play something and it's like whoa, and it breaks the conversation among sentient beings. I've become a fan. So it's very, very difficult. What's — to answer your question why does one guy get a call? Because he's a better hang. If there's five good piano players the good hang gets the call. Why? Because it's not just about the conversation on the bandstand, it's about the conversation off the bandstand, it's about the spirit and the vibe that sets up the performance or that allows the performance to be uninhibited. Or he might be on time, might be dressing well, who knows? And then some people would opt for the opposite of that. Maybe the other guy gets the call because he breaks the rules and people prefer guys that break the rules. People prefer guys that make mistakes and then figure out how to get out of it. So it's like all of the five piano players are going to be working and like water seeks its level they will all — all the five piano players will be in situations where they are supposed to be. Did you ever see the letter that was written by a Monk student that was online? And you know it was just like he wrote down Monk's observations.

MR: Oh I might have seen that, like if you don't hear anything —

DT: Correct. And you know the drummer makes the sound of the band, and don't ever ask for a gig just shed and a gig will come to you. My favorite one was the last one, he was quoted as saying, "They keep trying to get me to hate white people but somebody always comes along and fucks it up." I love that. That's great.

MR: Okay let's talk about a typical week or two weeks for you when you're not on the road, in New Orleans. I'm going to guess that you, in order to make a living as a musician —

DT: I was painting my house, a pretty kind of sea green color. All the things I do are related to music. Because first of all my father was a symphony conductor, a wonderful violinist. He could sight read a transposed score on piano, don't ask.

MR: Oh man.

DT: Yeah. Freaky stuff. And my mother was a world renown flamenco dancer. So you know I grew up in a culturally very rich household. Twenty years ago I took her to Spain and they'd stop flamenco performances and say, "Ladies and Gentlemen, please we have" — so there was gypsies around the house. My father used to turn his violin over and jam with flamenco guitarists you know who couldn't read music. So there was always this very rich, the flamenco, the Spanish people describe something called duende, which is kind of an inner magic that all artists that we love have. We can't describe it but it's there. And you know the classical music, just my father used to love the Ellington quote there's only two kinds of music, good and bad. So you know my father used to love to improvise within classical music, and my mother actually choreographed interesting — made different sized wooden boxes that were kind of little risers of different lengths. And she choreographed a Bach toccata and fugue for flamenco dancers. You know that they actually — she devised a notation for heel work and so the Bach toccata and fugue was realized with flamenco dancers approximating the pitches. It was cool. It was cool. Excuse me. I diverted again from your question, what's a typical two weeks for me. I love, I immerse myself in music, all kinds of music. And I like to go see music, I like to play music, I used to be director of broadcasts for Voodoo Music and Arts Experience. You wouldn't think that somebody that plays jazz music likes EDM — electronic dance music. You know. I mean these guys program some great stuff and they press play and they become cheerleaders. And lights and you know, raging kids. I mean it's cool. But there's some of those guys that open up sections in that music for cats to blow over. And so I actually have a part time persona as a DJ and I bring like killer musicians and I open — and I try and do that. I'm also — I produce events, I curate like when Dr. John was alive he used to come out for special events and money to play two or three tunes and then Irma Thomas two or three tunes, then Kermit. Little mini jazz festival. And I score music for films and I do music for advertising. I just try, everything in music — I have a studio in New Orleans that I just use to create in.

MR: Do you ever have a situation like someone wants a jingle and someone comes in and like, "Okay we want it to go like 'It's turkey time at Cumberland Farms'" and you have to do something with that idea?

DT: I don't get approached for those. But I like your idea let me write that down. No I usually get approached with, "Hey this is the demographic we're trying to appeal to. Do you have" and they'll do some — I mean advertising people are notorious for, "Can you come

up with something that feels like cheese." And I'm saying, "Well your request is a good place to start." But no, I usually get asked a little bit more abstractly than that. It's not, you know that, that era of jingle is over, except that it's coming back. You know, [sings] Liberty, Liberty, Liberty. You know.

MR: I keep — every time I hear that I go I wonder who wrote that.

DT: Well he's getting paid number one, and he just did a major triad and do-re-mi, and he managed to get the product name in a short musical logo four times.

MR: Amazing.

DT: Liberty, liberty, that was three and four. So you know those gigs are good if you can get it. But that's sort of harkening back to [sings] "Buy Mennen." Where it's a sung jingle. Normally my requests are, not even — I just did one that was cool though, it was lean on me for Dove dishwashing soap and it was like washing the oil off birds' wings and it was cool. And we did it with Taj Mahal's daughter who sang so soulfully, it was great. It was great. So those are kind of fun to do. I try not to you know, to descend into the world's oldest profession too deeply.

MR: How do you figure out how to price those things?

DT: Man it's difficult. But the, you know, the union is no longer relevant as far as setting those prices because broadcast has gone away. Everything has gone on-line. So that really did upset the applecart. It used to be like well is it local? Is it regional? Is it national? So I usually ask for too much money and sometimes the client goes away and sometimes they don't. So I actually have no idea. I mean I usually ask what's your budget and then they lie to me and I double it and you know.

MR: And you bring in, is it mostly keyboard-generated music or do you bring in people?

DT: It depends. You know I was the composer for a USA TV series called *The Big Easy*, which was loosely based on the movie. And the reason I was called was because first of all the rule of a movie or a television program is the lamer it is the more music it needs. Well this was damn near wall to wall music.

MR: I've got to write that down.

DT: Yeah. But also I used many New Orleans indigenous musicians. And I find it, you know if you get Donald Harrison to come in and go [scats] it has more emotion than you can possibly do on a keyboard, yeah. When there's jeopardy and there's drones involved then, you know, I'll take a sample of a marching band tuba and I'll effect it. So there's things you can do. But I like to start with human beings.

MR: Okay. Speaking of human beings, singers, playing behind singers.

DT: I was the pianist with Dianne Reeves for nine years.

MR: I read that.

DT: And it's a very, very intimate relationship. Like just when they're singing out of time it's like you start to learn to listen for the mouth opening because you know they're about to go [sings] I — and you know where the down beat is. So it's a very, you know the best that I've ever heard, besides Jimmy Rowles and the old guys, is Mulgrew Miller. He was so good, he was so good at it. Billy Childs was really great at it. You know there's a lot of great accompanists. I was never on that level. But I could always intuit phrasing pretty well.

MR: You had a little anecdote about on the radio thing playing behind David Bartholomew and he was playing "Body and Soul" and he — it sounded to me like maybe he dropped a beat here and there.

DT: Well he definitely dropped a beat and you know, and the same thing with singers. It's not about being right and wrong, you make whatever — no. Your role as an accompanist is to justify what happens. You're accompanying them. And just because they may have gotten a point off on their musicology final exam doesn't mean that you leave them out to dry, and especially a griot, an icon as Dave Bartholomew. But Dr. John called me up at the radio station, "Yeah I heard what you did bro, that was nice."

MR: You caught that, you fixed that.

DT: Yeah. That was slick.

MR: What should a singer —

DT: Now I'll say this though as an aside. Dr. John could play Bill Evans' tunes. He was a musician of the highest order. When you hear Dr. John play "Waltz for Debbie" it's like transformative. But obviously he wasn't known for that, but he was a good musician. Sorry you were going to —

MR: Well what would you tell an aspiring singer to have ready when they go — they're going to sit in in a club or they're trying to get their name out there. What should they bring to the table besides —

DT: Knowledge — know what tune they want to sing. If they're sitting in, is that what you're saying?

MR: Yeah.

DT: Know what tune they want to sing. Make it a tune or two or, your first objective is to, after the end of a tune would be asked to sing another. If you're asked to sit down after the first tune you got to go back to the shed. But first of all pick a tune that plays to the strength of the band. If the band is a swinging band, you know, pick a swing tune and trade with the drummer, you know, really interact. They're not there to back you up. Even on a gig if it's your band, they're not there to back you up, you're one of the musicians. You're part of the interplay. And also, very important, know your key. I mean I could not tell you how many times I asked the singer, "Okay, what key?" "Uh, I don't

know." [sings] Look at me. And I'm, you know. Yeah. So I would say that. And you know as just in terms of how you approach the music don't sing any words longer than you say them. The rendering of a lyric to communicate with the common man, people are bombarded with all kinds of stuff. Now Frank Sinatra, you know some of my favorite singers don't have very good voices: Frank Sinatra, Tony Bennett. They didn't have great voices. But they knew how to render a lyric. And you know that concept is like when you cook a piece of meat you're rendering the fat. When you render a lyric you're excising the meaning out of every syllable. That's what rendering a lyric is. And you're telling a story. So don't be so in your head that you're concentrating on how you sound and by all means don't scat unless you've transcribed solos. Because singers, many singers, and some, many great singers think they can scat [scats] and it's all bullshit. You know there's a singer in Manhattan named Veronica Swift. She is the next big thing. She's transcribed Freddie, you can, I mean she's deep, deep, deep. So don't scat. Because it's been done so well already that unless you're good you're going to get exposed.

MR: Wow. Great answers. I was watching you play.

DT: Speaking of exposed, I was watching you play.

MR: I was watching you play on that video and trying to imagine what's going on in your head. Because you were playing "Body and Soul" and I think you started with the bridge as a matter of fact, or it was almost like you played the bridge as an intro.

DT: Right.

MR: So I'm going to assume that was done on the spot?

DT: Oh sure.

MR: Okay. But then — I'll shorten the question. Can you tell me what you're thinking about when you're improvising?

DT: Those two are dichotomous. It's like can you tell me what you're thinking about when you're making love to your wife? Well if you're thinking about anything it's like that's totally not part of the process. Same thing with improvising. I mean the idea is to just let your inner voice take over. I mean, and you know, some people sing along with their solos. I'm not a big fan of that because I think that kind of locks you into —

MR: What your voice can do.

DT: Yeah. But great musicians such as Louis Armstrong could play anything they could sing and they could sing anything they could play you know. Erroll Gardner used to sing [moans]. I have a great DAT recording of Albert Collins doing a guitar solo, but the amp is in another room. It's just a microphone, his talk-back microphone and you can hear his strings going — you can hear acoustically his strings, but he's going [moans] it sounds like a demonic possession. It's unbelievable. I'm sorry. I'm digressing again.

MR: What you're describing obviously takes years of like preparation and knowledge so that you can —

DT: Let go.

MR: So that you can let go and not have to think too hard.

DT: I mean let me say this, my solo piano playing is pretty much the least interesting thing I've ever heard. You know like you hear Ellis Marsalis sit down and play, when he was filling in for Ellis Larkin at the Carnegie Lounge in Manhattan — just wonderful, flowing lyrical, delicate, grooving, swinging stuff. And you know I hear my solo stuff back and like for instance two years ago I did a solo piano set at Newport. And you know I just didn't feel good about it at the time. As a matter of fact before the hit I got a call from *The New York Times* guy and he said, "Hey, man I'd really love to interview you about your upcoming Newport performance, how about if we talk right after the set?" So I finished the set and the guy came up and said, "Hey man, that was really good, listen I have another interview. Why don't you just give me a call." So I'm like cool, thanks. My solo piano is a work in progress. I'm not a huge stride player which, what am I doing playing with Evan Christopher. But I do have some unique New Orleansisms that are informed by my heroes like Dr. John, like James Booker, and I incorporate them into my playing, not in a considered way but it's been infused. So I'm not thinking about anything. I didn't even know what I was going to play. I was probably referencing in my mind that Dave Bartholomew moment when I started playing "Body and Soul." 'Cause Mac called me in, it was for Mac. So yeah, I try not to — sometimes I'm more abstract. I try to think of shapes you know. I mean Kenny Werner, Richie Beirach, you know, all these cats have come up with new harmonic approaches and I try to at least allude to that. One time I was in Mount Fuji jazz festival playing with Dianne and it was a monsoon typhoon outside. Everybody was jet-lagged, they were up in the lobby at two or three in the morning and Herbie and Mulgrew and a bunch of other cats, Herbie was doing a piano master class on the piano in the lobby. And somebody asked, "Herbie, man, what are those changes at the end of 'Dolphin Dance'?" He goes, "Oh I used to play this and now I play this." And it was like oh my God I never even thought about that. So I just, to this day I take those voicings that he showed me and try to you know, hear them without, oh I know what this is. I try to hear them. It's difficult. But when I'm playing I try not to, I'm just trying to make it through.

MR: Make it through. From point A to point B or skip B and —

DT: Yeah. And I mean sometimes I'll take a left and, oh wait a minute, and then I'll go here. So it's sort of a journey. It's not evolved like I like, but I'm still working at it.

MR: Sometimes I'm mystified by the substitution chords that people come up with.

DT: And like reharmonizations?

MR: Yeah.

DT: Well you can overdo that for sure. I mean the whole point of it is there are no chords. Jazz is a counterpoint between the bass and the melody. And you know, the chords are implied by that counterpoint. You know, the true jazz musician doesn't pay attention to vertical constructs. Okay, C seven [scats], okay, B flat seven. I mean you're not supposed to. I mean that's not the point. That's popular music. You know jazz music is linear, it's linear, it's Don Cherry, it's World Saxophone Quartet, it's —

MR: Even Ellington, his writing was more like that. He had all those lines going on.

DT: Correct. Matter of fact one of my best courses at Berklee was Herb Pomeroy's Line Writing class. And it's like you started with this note and you ended with this note and you're whole thing was to write an interesting melody. Now the bass, or the next voice, just start at this point, end at this point, and write an interesting melody. And then look, I mean the strength of the melody is so strong that the harmony makes itself. It's like Nicholas Payton can play, we were playing a D minor construct, D minor something, modal, whatever. He can play something in E flat minor or something totally — and he can just shape it with such intent — listen, what's the difference between jazz music and classical music? At least it used to be. Classical music was principally about execution and very little about intent. Jazz music is exactly the opposite. It's mostly about intent and not as much about execution. Now Wynton and other accomplished musicians have changed that aesthetic. But like for instance Kermit Ruffins, you've heard of him? He can barely play the trumpet. But every note he plays sounds meaningful, and it draws you in. Because he means it. Like Louis Armstrong did.

MR: Wow. You hung out with Danny Barker and Erroll Garner?

DT: Well in my senior year of high school I had a gig with Walter Lastie, it was my gig but Walter Lastie was the drummer. He was one of Herlin Riley's uncles, and we had a band when Herlin Riley played trumpet. He played trumpet before he played drums. And a bass player, and Sam Alcorn, a great trumpet player, and we had a gig at the top of a hotel, it was late night, I missed all my morning classes. And then we transitioned to a club on Bourbon Street, a mob joint called the Stage Door Canteen, which was modeled, actually the same people as the one in New York. And we were the house trio. We played behind — they'd bring in comics, we played behind them. We'd play our own set. And for two weeks they brought in the Erroll Garner Quartet. Erroll Garner. Jimmy Smith on — the drummer Jimmy Smith. Eugene Wright –- McCarney I think it was, on bass, and Jose Manuala on trumpet. It was so killing. And during those two weeks Erroll Garner gave me some piano lessons. So that's how I got to hang out with him. Yeah. I have been fortunate to be able to come in at the end of an era and still, you know, through Dianne

Reeves and through just various associations, been very fortunate to have had the chance to play with some iconic musicians.

MR: Did — I'm not sure how to phrase this question. But Danny Barker and Erroll Garner, they obviously didn't go to Berklee. They didn't?

DT: Oh no, no. As a matter of fact Erroll Garner didn't — couldn't read music.

MR: That's what I'm trying to get at.

DT: And Danny Barker could read chord changes, but he was a very natural musician. But that's another example of what I was talking about earlier as far as New Orleans musicians affecting — their culture affecting — like for instance Danny Barker moved to New York, played with Charlie Parker, played with Cab Calloway, he played behind Billie Holiday. His wife, Blue Lu Barker, is cited by Billie Holiday as being one of her major early influences as far as how she approached — and you know Blue Lu Barker came out, she came out in New Orleans, you know from the New Orleans streets. It was completely unsullied by music education. It was purely from the human experience, and their particular human experience that happens in humidity, it happens in the social economic tension that's in New Orleans, you know, not racial per se, but it's a very complex and ever-changing myriad of energies. Not to sound too metaphysical.

MR: That sounds great. You mentioned sort of an aside, like well I'm not a great stride player and here I am playing with Evan Christopher.

DT: Yeah he puts up with my faux stride.

MR: Your faux stride. But as a working musician you have to adapt constantly, especially if you're in the role of a sideman.

DT: Sure. When I played keyboards with Boney James there was no stride to be had — you didn't need stride. I just needed sounds, and you know, understanding that he is not a bebopper. But his first influence was Grover and the great musicians in that smooth jazz world like Kirk Whalum. I mean all these wonderful musicians that are playing in an artificial format but it's just funk music, it's just an instrumental pop music is all it is. And so as a New Orleans musician I've played many different styles. I've played piano for silent movies. You know, just different things. And it's all fun. It's all great.

MR: I'm going to turn to a question around that I asked earlier about why of five piano players does one get the gig. What would cause you, if you had a steady gig somewhere and you had sidemen and sidewomen, what would cause you to fire somebody?

DT: Have I ever fired anybody?

MR: Or not —

DT: I only did that one time. I had a trio gig in New Orleans, George Porter was the bass player, great drummer named Troy Davis, who played a lot with who's the Jamaican piano player, Monty Alexander, a really good player, played with Terence Blanchard one

time or two, a really great New Orleans drummer. He was going out for a month with Monty. And I said well just send me somebody good. And he sent one of his students, a brilliant drummer named Simon Lot. So he called me a month later and he goes, "Hey bro I'm back in town, what's up?" And I go, "Bro, I don't really know how to tell you this but the guy you sent played you off the gig." He was that good. This cat had perfect balance. He sounded — he made everything we played sound like a Blue Note record. He was killer. Had good drumming bass chops, you know, he had all the language. And so I've never done that before or since and he's probably still a little pissed at me for it, but what would cause me to fire somebody? Bad attitude or ineptitude. 'tude.

MR: 'Tude. Yeah. Some you need, some you don't.

DT: Yeah. I mean I've fired people from studio recording sessions but never fired them and not paid them. It's just like in the studio, and I learned this from George Duke, you don't hire a musician and then try to get them to play how you want in the studio, you get musicians that already play how you want. Because otherwise you're not going to get — I mean my mantra in the studio is it doesn't have to sound good. It just has to sound real. You know some of the best — what are the best music recordings live? Because it's real. It's not like, "Take seven." Or let's comp this solo together. It's human and it's real. So I've only replaced people on recordings. I've never really replaced people on the gig unless they're unreliable or show up late or show up fucked up, or I should say too fucked up. So yeah, I haven't done it. I always —like Walter Lastie told me a long time ago, if you keep fast company you get fast. So I always try to hire the best musicians possible.

MR: Okay here's a really personal question. What do you think of the record "Green Onions?"

DT: You talking about Booker T?

MR: Yeah.

DT: I mean it's classic. I fucking love that record. I love it.

MR: The reason I thought of it is because you said it just has to sound real. And I'm so fascinated by that record because like first of all it's just got that sound, but when Steve Cropper comes in on his solo it's like really too loud and then it gets too soft, and then it gets just right. And I was thinking man, if they had said, "Look the balance is off, do it again, do it five more times."

DT: I love people that make records and leave mistakes on their records. I love that. It's just like come on — it's a snapshot in time, and it's again, where intent trumps execution. I try not to work in the studio with any engineer that doesn't know what this is [gestures]. "Where's the guitar solo, where's the guitar solo, oh it's around my neck." You know? I mean we can all perform meticulously perfect sonic surgery with ProTools and I've used ProTools as well. But, 'cause it's a studio standard and it's great, it's multi-tracks

everybody can afford. But the process is nothing that sounds like tape. There's nothing that sounds like vinyl. It's just, come on. I don't want to hear decoded zeroes and ones, when I can hear etched lacquer.

MR: I remember the first time I saw that in the studio though I go what are you doing? You're cutting the tape.

DT: Right. Right. Based on where that kick drum is, oh there it is, mark it.

MR: Wow. Do you have goals? Musical goals?

DT: There's a great drummer named John Vidacovich in New Orleans that I played with a long time ago in the Astral Project, and we get to play together some, just a wonderful painter. And I heard him on the radio and the radio DJ said, "What's your plans for the future?" And he goes, "Wow man, I hope to make my gig on time tonight." So my goals are to — not be forgotten— record more. I just did, I told you I did this Newport record which I've been kind of editing on and working on. I'll tell you a cool story. I thought how great would it be if George Wein did an intro for it, like he was on stage. So you know I went to his apartment, and he's 93, and we visited for an hour talking, because I'm on the board of the New Orleans Jazz Festival which he started. And we were talking about things. And finally I realized, oh he's getting tired now. I put a microphone in his hand, "George, you know what I need." "Oh yeah." And he hung his head for a minute. And I go oh shit, I'm overtaxing a 93-year-old man. He's 96 now, or 95 now. And he finally raised his — "Many years ago I played on Bourbon Street with Red Norvo and Red Garland" — no, no, sorry. "Many years ago I played on Bourbon Street with Red Norvo and Barney Kessel. Across the street was Al Hirt, and a young man playing with Al Hirt was Ellis Marsalis. And he and I became fast friends. We hung out every night. Now New Orleans grows musicians, and one of Ellis's protégés is a young man named David Torkanowsky. He played with Dianne Reeves and many great jazz artists and I've heard him play over the years and I said this man belongs at Newport. Ladies and gentlemen, David" he did that shit in one take. And I went oh my God what a gangster. He's just the definition of the promoter, entrepreneur. So — and he was also a good pianist in the Dick Hyman school.

MR: It's not a bad school to be.

DT: No. And he has this beautiful piano and this beautiful old pre-war New York apartment as you can imagine, it's spacious and beautiful and expensive. And I said, "George, man, let me get an engineer and a rig over here, we'll get a Anat Cohen over here and we'll get a bass player and let me do a record." And he goes ahh. I'm having trouble hearing you know, my time. And I said, "George your time was never that good to begin with bro, trust me." Anyway he didn't want to do it.

MR: Well I have enjoyed the heck out of this conversation.

DT: Thanks, man.

MR: And I'm looking very forward to hearing you tomorrow.

DT: Okay. When my left hand falters on my faux stride don't laugh, I'll know it's you.

MR: By the way I'm going to ask later, I'm going to ask Neal this question, I thought I'd ask you, in a piano trio who's responsible — is any — is the bassist or the drummer more responsible for the time?

DT: You would naturally probably tend to say the drummer but I'll say this. I did a big band for the hundredth anniversary of Sinatra. And we got the original Nelson Riddle charts and Count Basie charts and Sammy Cahn? No. Another one of his bands. And we had Harry Shearer, we had a bunch of artists. And it was killer. Hand picked a big band, we rehearsed. And the drummer, I'm not going to say his name, cause he's brilliant at everything and I'm surprised that he even played big band as well. I mean you could just Grady Tate it and you don't have to [scats] you don't have to do that, just swing. Anyway, this drummer missed the rehearsal due to a family illness and it was just Neal. Neal swung the fuck out of that band, just without a drummer. So I'm going to say probably both but the bassist, it depends on how assertive he is and how willing he is to agree or disagree. I mean if you listen to Mingus's band, him and the drummer never really played time together but they agreed to disagree and it was still swinging. So again it's that forward motion. It's like we don't have to get there in lock step but let's go to the same place. So.

MR: Well said. Okay. Thank you very much.

DT: You're welcome man, my pleasure.